

FILM DOSSIER: GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY

Phase 2 · Film #6 (Saga Film #14)

Status:  DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

1. IDENTITY

Field	Entry
Film #	14 of 29 (Phase 2, Film #6)
Phase	Phase 2
Real title	<i>GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY</i>
Decoy / codename title	<i>"MIXTAPE"</i>
Release date	Friday, August 1, 2014
Distributor	Walt Disney Studios Motion Pictures
Director	James Gunn
Rating / runtime	PG-13 · 152 minutes
Genre + second genre	Superhero action-adventure + space opera / ragtag heist comedy

2. OWNERSHIP

Field	Entry
Whose film / franchise is this?	The Guardians ensemble , led by Chris Pratt (Star-Lord). All of these roles have had only one real actor each, so no picks are needed.

Character	Actor	Age at release
Peter Quill / Star-Lord	Chris Pratt	35
Gamora	Zoe Saldña	36
Drax the Destroyer	Dave Bautista	45
Rocket Raccoon	Bradley Cooper (<i>voice</i>) / Sean Gunn (<i>on-set performance</i>)	39 / 40
Groot	Vin Diesel (<i>voice</i>)	47
Adam Warlock / The Magus	Will Poulter (<i>both roles</i>)	21
Mantis	Pom Klementieff	28
Nebula	Karen Gillan	26
Thanos	Josh Brolin (<i>on-set performance capture</i>)	46
Death	Aubrey Plaza (<i>see casting note</i>)	30
Taneleer Tivan, the Collector	Benicio del Toro	47
Stan Lee (<i>cameo: a Xandarian chatting up a woman on Knowhere</i>)	Stan Lee	91

Casting note, applied to the whole saga: under the Casting Rules, Mistress Death is played by Aubrey Plaza, the only real actor to have played Marvel's Death. She has played the silent hooded woman since Iron Man (2008, age 23), and the earlier dossiers are updated to match.

3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

Field	Entry
Primary comic(s) adapted	<i>Guardians of the Galaxy</i> vol. 2 #1–4 (2008), Dan Abnett & Andy Lanning: the modern Guardians form : Star-Lord, Gamora, Drax, Rocket, Groot, Adam Warlock and Mantis. Jim Starlin's "Magus Saga" , <i>Strange Tales</i> #178–181 & <i>Warlock</i> #9–11 (1975): Adam Warlock vs. the Magus , his evil future self, and the Universal Church of Truth , with Thanos and Gamora as Warlock's uneasy allies.
Supporting comics	<i>Iron Man</i> #55 (1973, Drax, created to kill Thanos) · <i>Strange Tales</i> #180 (1975, Gamora , Thanos's adopted daughter) · <i>Marvel Preview</i> #4 (1976, Star-Lord) · <i>Incredible Hulk</i> #271 (1982, Rocket Raccoon) · <i>Tales to Astonish</i> #13 (1960, Groot) · <i>Avengers</i> #112 (1973, Mantis) · <i>Avengers</i> #257 (1985, Nebula) · <i>Fantastic Four</i> #66–67 (1967, " Him," who becomes Adam Warlock)
Nerf check	✅ Drax, built to kill Thanos, attacks him and loses. On 616, Thanos is stronger. Warlock beats the Magus with the Soul Gem , at full cosmic power.

3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

Field	Entry
Overall accuracy score	95%. It combines the 2008 team formation with Starlin's 1975 Magus Saga. Every character comes from 616.

Straight from the page:

- **Gamora is the last of the Zen-Whoberi. Thanos took her as a child** and made her "**the deadliest woman in the galaxy**" (*Strange Tales* #180).
- **Drax the Destroyer: Arthur Douglas**, an Earthman killed by Thanos, whose spirit was put into a new body by **Mentor and Kronos** for one purpose: **to kill Thanos** (*Iron Man* #55).
- **Star-Lord: Peter Quill**, a half-human boy whose mother was murdered by alien invaders. He grew up to be a **space-faring outlaw** (*Marvel Preview* #4).
- **Rocket** (a gun-toting raccoon from **Halfworld**) and **Groot** (a *Flora colossus*, "**I am Groot**").
- **Adam Warlock** carries **the Soul Gem on his forehead**. The **Magus** is **his own evil future self**, who rules the **Universal Church of Truth**. **Thanos helps Warlock** against the Magus **for his own reasons** (the Magus Saga).
- **Nebula** claims to be **Thanos's granddaughter** (616) and hates him and Gamora.
- **Mantis** is an empath and martial artist.

Changes and why:

| Change | Why |

|---|---|

| The 2008 team forms during the 1975 Magus Saga | It puts the Guardians and Thanos's family in the same story |

| Quill's age (35) | Matches Pratt; the 616 details are the same |

POWERS & ABILITIES

Character	616 powers & abilities	Shown in this film	Held back (why)	Match
Star-Lord	Half-Spartax; expert pilot and marksman; element guns; a tactician	All of it	His Spartax heritage (later)	✓ 100%
Gamora	Enhanced by Thanos: superhuman strength, speed and healing; the deadliest woman in the galaxy	Takes apart a squad of Church Blackguards alone	–	✓ 100%
Drax	Superhuman strength and durability; cosmic energy blasts from his hands; flight ; built for one purpose (<i>Iron Man</i> #55)	Flight, cosmic blasts, going head to head with Thanos (and losing)	–	✓ 100%
Rocket	Tactician; weapons genius; pilot	All of it	–	✓ 100%
Groot	Regrows from a twig , grows at will, tremendous strength ; controls plants	Wraps the team in a protective sphere of branches; regrows from a twig	–	✓ 100%
Adam Warlock	Cosmic energy manipulation , flight, the Soul Gem (takes souls into itself), super strength, cocoon regeneration	All of it; the Soul Gem takes the Magus's soul into it	–	✓ 100%
The Magus	Warlock's powers, amplified ; commands the Universal Church of Truth	A fight that splits a planet	–	✓ 100%
Mantis	Empathy , precognition, master martial artist	Senses Thanos's intentions (see below)	–	✓ 100%
Nebula	Cybernetic enhancements; expert fighter and pirate	Fights Gamora to a draw	–	✓ 100%
Thanos	Class-100+ strength , near-invulnerable, cosmic energy blasts, a genius beyond any mortal	Swats Drax aside with one hand ; seen in the post-credit scene with two Gems	Everything else (Phase 3)	✓ 100%

4. STORY

Field	Entry
Logline	An Earth-born outlaw, a raccoon, a tree, a vengeful brute and the daughter of the Mad Titan have to save the galaxy from a god-man's evil future self, with Thanos watching the whole time.
Theme	Family you choose. Every Guardian has lost a family, and they find one in each other.
Villain / antagonist	The Magus and the Universal Church of Truth (main); Nebula ; Thanos (in the shadows)

What the movie is about

ACT ONE: THE BARGAIN

- **1988, Missouri:** young Peter Quill watches **alien invaders kill his mother**. He's taken into space.
- **Present day (Monday, May 19, 2014): Star-Lord**, an outlaw, steals a relic from a temple, and it turns out to be the location of **Adam Warlock's cocoon**.
- Every bounty hunter in the galaxy comes after him: **Rocket and Groot**, and **Gamora**, who has been sent by **Thanos**.
- **Drax** hears the name "Thanos" in a Knowhere bar and charges.
- The four of them, and eventually **Mantis**, end up running for their lives together.

ACT TWO: WARLOCK

- The cocoon opens, and **Adam Warlock** comes out with a **green Gem burning on his brow**.
- Warlock warns them about the **Universal Church of Truth**, which is led by **the Magus**, his own future self and a tyrant who worships himself.
- The Church hunts the team. **Nebula**, the Magus's hired pirate, fights Gamora.
- **Thanos appears**. He offers **an alliance** against the Magus. Drax attacks him on sight, and **Thanos swats him aside with one hand**.
- **Mantis**, touching Thanos's mind: *"He's in love. And it's the most frightening thing I've ever felt."*

ACT THREE: GUARDIANS

- The final assault on the Church's cathedral world, with Thanos's forces fighting alongside the heroes.
 - **Warlock vs. the Magus**. Warlock uses **the Soul Gem on his own future**. The Magus is **drawn into the Gem**, screaming.
 - **Thanos** asks for the **Soul Gem**. Warlock refuses. Thanos smiles: *"In time, Warlock."* and leaves.
 - Gamora doesn't go with him. **She stays**.
 - Quill looks at the six of them: *"What do we call ourselves?"* Rocket: *"Something stupid, probably."* Quill: *"The Guardians of the Galaxy."*
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5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

Field	Entry
When it's set	1988 (prologue) · Monday, May 19, 2014 → Saturday, July 12, 2014 (Earth dates). The post-credit scene takes place the same week .
Where it's set	Missouri, 1988 · Knowhere (a mining colony inside the severed head of a Celestial) · the Collector's museum (rebuilt) · the Universal Church's cathedral world · deep space (filmed on practical sets at Shepperton Studios, and in Iceland and Morocco)
Relative to other films	Three months after <i>The Amazing Spider-Man</i> . Quill's Walkman mixtape is the only piece of Earth he has left.

6. WORLD-BUILDING

The film's own world

- **The Guardians**, **Knowhere**, the **Universal Church of Truth**, the **Magus**.
- **Adam Warlock** and **the Soul Gem**.
- **Thanos's family**: Gamora, Nebula, and Drax, his living curse.

World-building for the wider MCU

Seed	How it appears	Payoff
The Soul Gem is in play	Warlock wears it	<i>The Infinity Gauntlet</i> (on 616, Warlock is central to it)
Earth is known	Quill mentions "a planet with Avengers now." Rocket: " <i>Sounds made up.</i> "	Phase 3 crossover
The Kree	A Kree warship passes by in the background	Captain Marvel (Phase 3)

Setting up the Big Bad

Seed	How it appears	What it means
Thanos, in person	His first full scenes and dialogue in the MCU	He's real, and he's here.
"He's in love."	Mantis reads his mind	Death is the reason.
The Soul Gem	Warlock refuses him: " <i>In time.</i> "	Thanos will come for it.
Two Gems	The post-credit scene	The Thanos Quest continues.

7. POST-CREDIT SCENES

Field	Entry
Mid-credit scene	✓ "DANCE." On the Guardians' ship, a tiny sapling Groot , regrowing in a pot, dances to Quill's mixtape whenever Drax isn't looking. Drax is looking.
Post-credit scene	✓ "THE CHAMPION." An arena world. The Champion of the Universe , an Elder, huge and scarred, lies beaten in the sand of his own arena. Thanos stands over him and pulls a second Gem from the Champion's belt. It sets into the Gauntlet with a sound like thunder. At the arena gate, Death (Aubrey Plaza) watches. THANOS: <i>"Two, my love."</i> She turns and walks away. CUT TO BLACK. "THE GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY WILL RETURN."
Secret shoot codenames	Mid-credit: " GARDENING. " Post-credit: " WRESTLEMANIA. "

CHECKLIST

- [x] Comic(s) adapted · [x] Comic Accuracy Report + powers · [x] Real and decoy titles · [x] What it's about · [x] Villain · [x] Post-credit scenes · [x] The film's own world-building · [x] MCU world-building · [x] Big Bad setup · [x] Whose franchise · [x] When and where in the timeline